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Howard Johnson

Howard Johnson is a virtuoso on the tuba, baritone saxophone, and pennywhistle, and has collaborated with Gil Evans, the "Saturday Night Live" band, and John Lennon, among many others. Howard directed and recorded with Gravity, his own innovative ensemble that included four tubas.

Howard was interviewed in New York City on January 14, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

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HJ: I said I didn't know what to expect coming to Texas Christian because I didn't know if I'd be able to cuss or not.

MR: And did you?

HJ: And the tuba teacher says, "Shit yes."

MR: Well let's get started. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm privileged to be in the home of Howard Johnson today. Thank you for allowing us to come and chat with you.

HJ: Well thank you for inviting me.

MR: I picture you going to a gig somewhere in Manhattan or New York and moving your tuba and your baritone saxophone and I wonder what that was like.

HJ: You mean transporting?

MR: Transporting.

HJ: I've been doing it since I was about 14 so it never seemed like that much of a task until I got in my present condition which is fairly out of whack.

MR: You just figured out how to deal with it.

HJ: Yeah. But I think it contributed to me being out of whack.

MR: Yeah that's a very physical — people don't think about the physical end of playing gigs and especially if you've got the low end thing happening.

HJ: Well you know a lot of people do think about it, they wonder if I wish I'd played the flute. To which I say the flute? I'm going to want to play the flute when I can do what I do with my instruments? I'm going to be happy playing a flute?

MR: I guess so.

HJ: I don't think so.

MR: And when you say what I can do with your instruments I wanted to share with you you're written up in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz* and they said that, "You rediscovered the idea of the tuba as a solo instrument despite its cumbersome nature." So I think I can agree with that when I listen to some of the tuba work you've done. And at the other end you've got the high end covered with the pennywhistle too?

HJ: Yeah. Well it's the only thing I play that's portable. You know you really do sometimes just want to play something and you don't have your tuba in your pocket. The pennywhistle is just the thing.

MR: Did you come from a musical family?

HJ: No. I've never gotten used to being asked that you know. Because I guess that's what happens to most people. They follow somebody else in their family who does play instruments. And sometimes they want to play so they can out-blow the old man or something like that, or to get girls.

MR: There's always that.

HJ: But yeah it seems like it comes up through families. There are no musicians in the family before me, although my father, I found out that my father set up the format for his church choir for certain songs. Most people knew the songs but if you're going to have a choir singing you have to have a format. So when that was explained to me, which was at my father's funeral, I said, "This guy's an arranger." And they said, "Well no he just had the basses go down over here and the sopranos up here. You know. So it's like the Temptations.

MR: What kind of music were you hearing in the house when you were growing up?

HJ: Everything. The radio was just about always on and my family, like many black families, well there wasn't that much black programming in the north in Ohio where I grew up. There was a little, there was a little on each channel. I think it had something to do with their charter or something like that. But if you knew your radio you could change the station when the Gospel finished, and put on the rock & roll or the jazz or whatever we might be interested in.

MR: Okay. So you didn't have a family that disallowed blues in the house?

HJ: Oh no. No it was a very secular thing. We knew those people but, in fact I even divided it up even more than that. The people who don't listen to the blues because it's the devil's music or something like that, still have a body of secular music that, that's part of their life too. You know you could say it's folksy or something like that. But you know when you hear people like King Curtis or "Fathead" Newman, that is David Newman, (we don't want to call him "Fathead" on this) — I worked with him the last two years of his life and I always found him a great guy.

MR: Yeah. He spent some good years with Ray Charles.

HJ: Ray Charles. And there's a difference between when he's playing his down home thing that's not the blues and if you listen to my latest CD you'll find a piece called "Little Black Lucille." "Little black Lucille was an aunt of mine who definitely wouldn't want to be on a blues record. And she never heard this tune being played with a rhythm section

MR: Well you spent some time at sea, correct?

HJ: You mean being in the Navy?

MR: Yes.

HJ: You make it sound like it was my choice. They put me on a ship and sent me out there.

MR: Okay. Did you like it?

HJ: Not much. No. It was a mistake that I discovered in boot camp, my first night in boot camp I went, what have I done?

MR: You mean you volunteered and then you —

HJ: Yeah that was the only way to get into the Navy, or you were drafted.

MR: Okay. Were you at a point at that time that you could have maybe done your time as a musician in the Navy?

HJ: Yeah they had a music program but they threw me out of it after about six months. There's a whole story about how that happened and a weird teacher I had who really disliked me a lot, but not more than I disliked him.

MR: Was the service segregated at that time?

HJ: Not officially. It was de-segregated right after World War II and I came along about eight years after that.

MR: Okay. Late 50s?

HJ: Yeah. But they had their ways of getting a message across. For instance we couldn't go to Iceland. We did a North Atlantic cruise and we went to Oslo and Kiel, Germany and Southampton in England, Rotterdam. And we were scheduled to go to Iceland at the end and they wouldn't let the black sailors off the ship. I mean it was no, I don't even think it was in the regulations or anything, they just enforced it. The reason for that, I was told when I complained loudly, is that after World War II when there were American forces in Iceland there were getting to be too many brown babies threatening the ethnic purity of the Icelanders, so the deal was made was that the brown babies had to go. If the mother wanted to go she could go too, but she couldn't raise her brown baby in Iceland at that time. I was incredulous. I couldn't figure that out. And I actually said to the Master at Arms, "Can I go to Iceland ashore if I promise to not fuck anybody?"

MR: I bet that didn't get you very far.

HJ: No they went ballistic, they went crazy and threatened to put me in the brig. I mean I wasn't doing so great where I was being just bossed around and I didn't see why I'd be a threat in Iceland.

MR: Did you run into John Surman in England?

HJ: Yes.

MR: He played a mean baritone sax, didn't he?

HJ: He did. Even then, he was 16 and we connected, the first time it was not in Southampton, Plymouth. So we played together in Plymouth at the art museum or the art school, something like that. Mike Westbrook played there too at that time.

MR: What kind of jazz first appealed to you?

HJ: Oh I don't know if I made all those delineations. If it was good music I liked it.

MR: Okay. That's a great answer.

HJ: For instance, what could I say? I was greatly influenced by Louis Jordan. Now Louis Jordan was very popular and his records, and you couldn't say they weren't jazz, they were the most modern jazz, and they were meant to be entertaining and funny and they were. They were rolickingly funny.

MR: Rolickingly. That's a good one. And he had the personality for it too, didn't he?

HJ: Yeah he did.

MR: To sell that.

HJ: Um hum. And people like that. Bull Moose Jackson for instance. If you listen to his stuff, if I listen to his stuff now it's very advanced from a lot of the other stuff. He was a good saxophone player. Louis Jordan was a good saxophone player. And I got into the bebop thing as well, which was the same time, very bebop, '50, '48, '45, and it all had pretty much the same value to me except I was a little more deeply touched by the bebop guys.

MR: Were you trying to play that music on the baritone sax?

HJ: Well see it's kind of funny and maybe notable, and I — I can't think of how to say it —

MR: To try to emulate, like Charlie Parker, what he's doing?

HJ: Oh well it's the idea of making up these different lines to fit over changes, chord changes, and also to just play even freer than that — that appealed to me a lot.

MR: Okay.

HJ: So even Count Basie was too locked down for me.

MR: He was too locked down?

HJ: Yeah. I mean he was tied to arrangements of course.

MR: Yes.

HJ: And even so, things like "One O'clock Jump" and that sort of thing, they made that up on the bandstand and when it was in good enough shape they recorded it. But all those guys contributed to it.

MR: Before I forget, a mutual acquaintance told me to ask you about "Madame Butterfly."

HJ: Who was that?

MR: He's a tuba player also, Joseph Daley.

HJ: Oh yes.

MR: I met him last summer and we were talking about you. So what's —

MR: No he did not. He said to ask you.

HJ: Oh. Well being the teacher's pet that I was in the first grade, I was helping my teacher clean out her closet and I found some recordings. It was about 1947, '46. And as far as I knew, records were the blues and Louis Jordan and all that sort of thing. And I knew that white people didn't listen to that kind of music. So I saw this record, these records, I said Mrs. Ferrell, you've got a record." She said, "Yes." She said, "You like records?" I couldn't believe she, you know, was listening to the same thing my sisters were, my bobby sox sisters. So she said, "Let me see that." And she looked at it and she said, "I've been looking for this for weeks, I went ahead and bought another one, would you like to have that?" And this was an idea or an opportunity for a political shift. Because I wasn't allowed to play records on my sisters' record player because they were afraid I might break it. But if I had a record of my own I could probably get through all that. So I hurried home and I said, "Is this a good record?" before I heard it. And she says, "Let me see that. Oh this is very good, this is — and I read it, it says 'Madame Butterfly." I thought Madame Butterfly, I could picture Madame Butterfly, about 300 pounds, wearing feathers in her hair and singing, "I got the world in a jug/and a stopper in my hand. I could just — I knew what it was going to sound like ahead of time. So when I got home I went straight to the record player, put this on and it was "é Belle" [sings] — in this high soprano. I was wondering what on earth is this. My family members started coming into the living room and they said, "What is that?" I said, "I don't know I thought it was a record." "That ain't no record."

MR: Your image of Madame Butterfly just changed quite a bit.

HJ: Yeah.

MR: That is a good story.

HJ: So that's kind of how grounded I was in stuff. It actually started me, this was the year that the Met started doing mid-day performances of opera. And I noticed that that kind of singing, screechy I thought, kind of singing was in a lot of the programming. It was just after the childrens' programming on Saturday so I would leave the radio on, listen to the overture and as far as I could get through the rest of it. But they're going [sings]. I'm like whoa, what is that?

MR: Well you got farther than a lot of people with that. It's an acquired taste.

HJ: Well I felt they wouldn't be recording this and taking it live and sending it across the country if something important wasn't going on. I may or may not be able to understand it but I listened to it anyway.

MR: Was there a point in your life, sort of a definite point when you decided, I'm going to try to make a living as a musician?

HJ: I'd have to say yes but I couldn't nail it down for you. By the time I thought I should be a musician I already was. And I liked the idea that I was doing something other people were not.

MR: Well at the time most people thought if a tuba was going to be in jazz then it would be old timey, perhaps early New Orleans music with a bomp-bomp-bomp type thing going on. There wasn't too many role models other than that for you to listen to, was there?

HJ: No but I was interested in anybody playing the tuba you know, whether it be Red Callender, the great bass player, who also in the 50s, in '54, put out a couple of jazz LPs with a rhythm section and Buddy Collette and his Friends playing those arrangements.

MR: Oh right, on the west coast.

HJ: Gerald Wilson. Yeah. And then there was Ray Draper who was just one year older than me but who had several technically, you know as far as playing the instrument, Bob Stewart and I had him come over to my loft one time and play some stuff for us. We found what the problem was, the technical problem. And that was what kept him from getting any farther. He had a beautiful soul thing, you know, that just didn't come across that well because of the inability to control the instrument and develop some range. But in the last year of his life, there's a lot of stuff together in the last month of his life he stayed at my loft on Vestry Street and he was killed in the street by mini-muggers who saw him having some money in the street and moved to take it from him. They killed him with a gun.

MR: I did not know that. That's awful. So you moved to New York, how do you find your way into the music community as a newcomer?

HJ: I had to find out what I had to find out. I didn't want to be denied the opportunity just cause I didn't show up. So there was no question of am I going to make it or, I just had to do what I had to do which was place myself in the right place. I didn't have a tuba when I came to New York. I brought my baritone sax and I looked for an opportunity to get a tuba. When I finally got one I went — I hadn't played in five years but I went the next day to a jam session place, back in the days when people who could play went to jam sessions. Now it's kind of a refuge for the fellas who don't have it together, you know? But at this jam session was Roland Kirk, Carla Bley, who started using the tuba for everything shortly after that, Paul Bley was there too. And even people who were just passing through town like Joe Albany, that's the only time I ever saw Joe Albany. And my chops wore out pretty quick because I hadn't been playing, as I said, in five years. But even with my chops worn out I could do a lot more than anybody expected of me.

MR: So I guess you made a good impression.

HJ: Yeah. I knew I would. I learned that expectations were so low. They used to say, "On the

MR: And they're not even used to hearing a tuba play the melody.

HJ: They're still not.

MR: They're still not.

HJ: This is something I hear every time. "I didn't know a tuba could do that." Well I mean I haven't been doing my job because I've been doing it since 1962 and people still don't know.

MR: Well I think you've informed a lot of people along the way. Do you recall the first time you met Charles Mingus?

HJ: Oh yes. Who can forget a thing like that? Can I be heard at all?

MR: Yeah. We're doing good.

HJ: Okay. It seems like my voice is fading as we speak.

MR: Feel free to take some water. We can pause, there's no problem with that at all.

HJ: Yeah let's.

[pause @ 28:00]

MR: We were talking about Charles Mingus.

HJ: Yeah. I used to go down to the Five Spot. The guys in there knew me and they didn't like dislike me or anything, the guys who owned the place, they were very tolerant of young musicians who wanted to hang and listen. And Mingus was there with a quintet with Charles McPherson, Lonnie Hillyer, Danny Richmond, and Jaki Byard. So I had met Jaki because I lived in — I had an apartment in Boston when I was in the Navy. And I met Jaki through Tony Williams, whose mother I rented the room from. So I'd already started playing the tuba, I'd been playing for about a year in New York. And I went to see Mingus. I didn't have any money. I would have liked to have spent some money but I just didn't have any. And they were kind of looking at me like oh this guy's hanging out again. So I was trying to sit in the back and be small so the Termini brothers wouldn't look at me so much. And Mingus had just finished his "Mingus at Monterey" recording, a big band with L.A. cats in it and his quintet. And he hired Red Callender to come and play the tuba on that date. So it was a great record, and when he came back to New York he wanted to play that music, that Monterey music, at Birdland, the old Birdland, with Pee Wee and everything — Pee Wee Marquette.

MR: Pee Wee Marquette.

HJ: And Mingus had — this night I came in the Five Spot — Mingus had just gotten the word that Red Callender wouldn't come east. He had contractual obligations and they wouldn't let him out to come —a whole week. So he had to call Mingus to tell him that that night. Mingus was not happy. Red Callender was his first bass teacher, I don't know, people don't realize that.

HJ: But Red Callender taught Mingus to play the bass. And so he was kind of angry and grumpy and everything else. And Jaki Byard, they were just about to take the stand and Jaki Byard said, "There's your tuba player over there." And Mingus, "You mean that kid?" Now at this point in the gig or whatever was going on, Mingus always called his band the Jazz Workshop. That gave him a chance to use anything you know. He could stop a band and rehearse a section that they didn't get so well. He could change the key or change the meter. Because it was the Jazz Workshop, right?

MR: Oh so he used that as a —

HJ: So when he spoke to the band from the bandstand, I mean, he almost always said into the microphone, so he pulled up the mic and he says, "You mean that kid back there? "Yeah, he's got a tuba but can he play it?" And Jaki didn't want to get too involved because he didn't know my playing. So he said, "I don't know, why don't you ask him?" And Mingus looked at me and said, "You play behind the beat like most tuba players?" I said, "No, I haven't been told that." So he said, "What tunes do you know?" Now at this point the audience was looking between Mingus and me wondering what's going on. Because they'd never seen people do that on the bandstand. Mingus said, "What tunes do you know?" I didn't understand the question, because I knew the tunes I needed to know to get along in New York. I was ready to play on whatever you called. Because that's what I thought a jazz musician did, not seek dispensation for it being a difficult instrument you know. It's like I actually heard a guy do that and he was kind of fumbling all over himself and I tried to mention that without trying to bust him. He says, "Hey man, it's a tuba, what do you want?"

MR: You wouldn't do that then.

HJ: No, no. So, because I didn't understand Mingus' question, I said, "What tunes do you want to hear?" The audience went, "Woooooh." A challenge being hurled. "Oh you're bad. Are you bad enough for that? Come on up here and we're going to see about this." So that's what I did. I went and played some blues tune or other. And the audience was cheering. And he said, "On that blues you were doubled up pretty fast on a couple of choruses. You couldn't play an uptempo tune, could you?" I said, "Yeah, I'm sure I can." So he called "Cherokee" you know, the big challenging fast tune. I had to run a couple of choruses of that. And the audience again was on the underdog's side. So Mingus said, "Okay we're playing Birdland the next five days" or something like that, opposite the Coltrane quartet. I was like, "Yeah, baby." So the first rehearsal is tomorrow afternoon here at the Five Spot. And the audience was going, "Yeah, yeah, yeah." They didn't stop. So he said, "I'd like to hear you play a ballad." It was under the auspices of the Jazz Workshop. So he asked me to play "Stormy Weather." And at some point in the tune

he said, "Okay, you've still got the gig but learn how to play 'Stormy Weather' right." So I went, "Well what was wrong with it?" He said, "You know the part that says, 'It's raining all the time/it's raining all the time.' You have to say that two times."

MR: He wanted you to tag it.

HJ: So I'm like, "Okay, you still win." I mean I wasn't trying to make it that but it got to be that.

MR: That's a great — that's some drama there, boy, that is jazz drama. I can just picture it, and the audience, like okay what's Mingus going to do next, and how's this young man going to respond. That's a really cool story. Wow. Just, and a long line, of I was trying to think of people who you haven't played with, and that's sort of hard. But you seemed to enter the jazz world with pretty progressive music, right? You played with Archie Shepp and some people say that much of that music sounds angry.

HJ: Yeah, they always said that.

MR: Yeah, what do you think about that?

HJ: Yeah. About Archie's especially because he was very aggressive. Well they called Coltrane angry. So much beauty in Coltrane, you know, whether it's fast or slow. It's almost delicate to me, you know, the loudest Coltrane stuff you can find seems delicate.

MR: I'm wondering if you — go ahead — if you ever turned, at that time, you're in New York trying to make a living, I imagine that the typical jazz gig, which you were happy to get, probably didn't pay that much? So did you ever turn down a gig at that time?

HJ: For not being it paid well enough?

MR: Yeah.

HJ: Yes. Usually the gig wasn't worth it anyway.

MR: What kind of gig might it have been?

HJ: Where there was any kind of hustle or hassle, you know I mean it had to be credible. I mean people who were paying enough money had the better gigs than the ones who didn't you know. I mean it was a matter of not so much the money but just principles.

MR: Were you ever asked to do the Dixieland thing?

HJ: Oh sure.

MR: Yeah.

HJ: Yeah, that was great. It's still great.

MR: As a tuba player you're the bass player.

HJ: Yeah.

MR: So you have to know the chord structure and how to get — I'm on this chord and I got to get to the next chord with some kind of movement. Was that something you learned before you played the instrument or did you learn it as you went along?

HJ: Ooh. Good question. Yeah. It's hard to say one or the other. The thing is I was always into the bass line, even the Louis Jordan records, the piano players were still playing eight to the bar [scats]. Like that. And I could tell that these root notes meant something to not only the piano players and the bass players, but all the guys who were playing. No one had ever said the word "chord changes" to me, but they were there and there's no missing them if you were listening. And I always liked arranging. I always liked what guys could do with what the structure was. How they could influence the structure even. I sometimes like to talk about my discovery of Gil Evans. Right after my sixteenth birthday my family had given me a transistor radio and you could walk along with it up to your ear. And my mother wanted me to go somewhere and take something. I didn't want to do it because I wanted to listen to the one-half hour a week jazz program on my local radio station. And it's that one-half hour a week with a guy named Wesley. He had "Jazz with Wesley" once a week. And he said one night, "Tonight I'm going to give you all my commercials and all my announcements before and after the music, because with this recording there's no place to break in, it just plays on and on for the whole side. It's a new one by Miles Davis, who is with a 19-piece orchestra, led by and arranged for by Gil Evans." I'm like Gil Evans, who is Gil Evans, I'd never heard that name before. Like I said, I was sixteen and I was a senior in high school. So then I had to go and do this task but I had my wonderful transistor radio and I could listen to it like that. But I didn't want to hear [scats] from a big band playing with Miles Davis? It didn't seem right. Well I would have been glad to hear Miles in almost any other context. But then the thing came on and it was that "Springsville" the first one on the LP [scats]. So I'm like whoa, what is this? It seems like there's a tuba in this ensemble. So I was completely captivated. I never did get to the place I was supposed to go on time, because I had to stop and listen for a little while. And it even got to be more tuba than that. I thought this Gil Evans guy is okay.

MR: And then years later —

HJ: Well I was looking for him around the same time I was looking for Mingus, because all I wanted to do was meet these guys you know. Ernie Wilkins, who did the great arrangement of "Every Day I Have the Blues," I met him someplace, and he actually said he didn't use tuba anymore. And I said, "Well you have to hear me." He said, "Well fine." He'd given the tuba to use in every context and it was all right much of the time but it was mostly wanting. So he didn't want to hear me play. So I got his phone number and called him up and his wife put him on the phone and I held the mic up here and the phone up here and started jamming. When I stopped I pulled the phone down and he was still laughing. He says, "Okay, man, give me your number."

HJ: And that was my first recording, was with Ernie Wilkins. But I spotted Gil Evans one night when I was playing with Mingus at the Five Spot. I thought oh, here's my chance — it's been two years and I haven't been able to find this guy. So I put my instrument up and came back out and he had left. I said oh no is it going to be another two years before I see him? But he called me about a couple of weeks later because he'd gotten my number from Mingus.

MR: Well he knew how to deal with the potential clash between the bass and the tuba it seems.

HJ: And the bass clarinet was in there too.

MR: Yeah.

HJ: It gave him about six different colors to use for the low notes. Sometimes the tuba was too heavy for the woodwinds but the bass clarinet is just right.

MR: Can we talk about some of the studio work you've done over the years.

HJ: Um hum.

MR: Typically if you got a call to come in and play on a session they obviously would tell you what they wanted you to bring, right?

HJ: Yes.

MR: But how much did you know about what was going to happen before you got there?

HJ: Nothing.

MR: Nothing.

HJ: Yeah they just kind of sprung that stuff on you. It would have been a little easier for me if I was a better studio cat, if I was a better reader. But I read well enough, if you know, they didn't demand that it be on the first take, you know, you get it all on the first take. You give me two takes, I got it.

MR: You hear it once and then you've got it.

HJ: Yeah.

MR: And that was typically you'd get paid for a three or four hour session.

HJ: Yeah. Three hour mostly.

MR: Um hum. And then you'd drop by the musician union at some point and —

HJ: Pick up a check.

MR: Say what do you got for me?

HJ: Yeah. I done that for a while. They still keep coming in.

MR: You still on occasion get something for something you played on?

HJ: Oh yeah.

MR: Oh that's nice. I guess it has to do something with if they air it as a commercial.

HJ: A lot of things.

MR: Yes. So occasionally you might hear on the radio, you might hear some music and you

HJ: Mostly if it's good I'll think it's somebody else.

MR: Now that's self-deprecating I would say.

HJ: Well I don't know, I think it has to do with my memory more than anything else.

MR: I jotted down a few — I think it's really fascinating that you played on "Escalator Over the Hill," and then you played with John Lennon. Is that true?

HJ: Yes. Not at the same time.

MR: Do you remember much about the John Lennon sessions?

HJ: Oh I'd say everything. It was a horn section. John had the track all ready and we were going to put horns on it. And he had this idea that he explained to us that horn players are real musicians, not like guys who just play guitar and drums and that sort of thing. And if you put a bunch of them together they'll just make magic happen. Well I knew most of the other guys. I knew that wasn't going to happen with this bunch because they were crabby and critical and stuff like that. And we spent, it was supposed to be two three hour sessions. Double session. And after that period of time we had nothing you know? I didn't want to say anything because I've been in situations before with one of those characters who when I was trying to help and improve something on some other gig, he said, "Well who made you the arranger?" You know? So I'm just trying to help you know. But I didn't say anything more after that. So we had only worked on one tune and we didn't have anything. And I spoke up and said, "Well look at this point I know the track very well from listening to it for over two hours, and I have some ideas if nobody minds." You know, aimed at these crabby guys. And they said, "For God's sake yes." So we played my ideas and that became the arrangement for that tune. And he said, he was very happy, he said, "We can do this again. Come tomorrow at the same time and we'll work through you if you don't mind." I said, "No, only too glad."

MR: Did you get to hear the next day's tune before you left?

HJ: No. Well not until the last day. Because it's a very paranoid world you know. And there was stuff going on that they were trying to keep undercover. For instance, that's when Yoko was away in China somewhere and he was with — I don't remember that name now — May Pang. And there would always be people outside the studio, Beatle fans who wanted to give him a beaded collar or some kind of thing or something, or a poem that they wrote in 1966 in honor of him. And you never knew who was going to be there. But he finally trusted me enough to give me a cassette of the next tunes. I wrote them out at home.

MR: Well that's really a great story and the fact that you had that skill and could finally speak up and say I know how to make this happen. Were those other horn players, were they older than you?

MR: I just wondered, maybe they had an attitude about.

HJ: Young whippersnappers?

MR: Say that again?

HJ: Young whippersnappers.

MR: Okay I'm going to play a little "Name That Tune" with you.

HJ: All right.

MR: But you have to put up with my sort of scat singing, okay? So it's sort of a funky beat, [scats] Did you get it yet?

HJ: Well yeah.

MR: I'm glad cause I didn't want to do that anymore.

HJ: That's my line, isn't it?

MR: That's your line. And it was apparently named after your late-1970s wardrobe.

HJ: Oh Raggedy Man.

MR: Raggedy Man. That's a great tune and I was listening to it and I went to the piano and I found the root and I said man you were blowing up a storm on the baritone sax in the key of F sharp, and I thought that was something. How does a tune like that come to be? Do you get inspired from somewhere?

HJ: I think I was actually looking for a tune like that that I could put certain things to it. And after a while it just emerged as a finished piece.

MR: It sounds a bit like something you could have used on "Saturday Night Live" to me.

HJ: I wish I'd thought of it.

MR: Yeah. Cause it was after that, right?

HJ: Yeah.

MR: So you made some appearances on television: *Sesame Street*, do those things come around because somebody knows somebody and yeah, Howard can do this?

HJ: Yeah. That's what does happen. When you say *Sesame Street* you're referring to "Jelly Man Kelly?"

MR: Yes I am.

HJ: Some kids used to see me in the mall or someplace and say, "Mommy, there's 'Jelly Man Kelly'" because they had that on home video.

MR: That's right. Well you added a lot to that. Was the "Saturday Night Live" gig sort of high pressure?

HJ: No.

MR: No?

HJ: No there was too many drugs for it to be high pressure. It would have collapsed under any kind of pressure.

HJ: This was people who were in the studios all week making extra bread for extracurricular activities and were glad to have the relief of an easy gig.

MR: You directed that band for a while, right?

HJ: The last season I was there. I was there five. I conducted it on the fifth.

MR: Do you remember when they came to you with this "King Tut" business?

HJ: I don't remember. I remember doing it.

MR: You remember doing it, yeah.

HJ: I was explaining to Nancy something the other day, and I saw it right after that. I mean I saw a little clip of "King Tut" but the stuff we were wearing came from the Met's production of "Aida." And they had the thing where they had the buzzard wings spread out and crossed in the front, and that's what they had the horn players wearing in the band. No tee shirt under it or anything you know, just this cross thing like that. It looked like an uplift bra on me.

MR: Oh Lord. And you were playing the bass sax, weren't you?

HJ: Yup.

MR: That's a fun thing to watch when Lou Marini came out of the sarcopha— or whatever you call that.

HJ: Sarcophagus

MR: Yes. You've just done so many things I don't know where to stop. I did want to ask you, you went to the West Coast for a while, and got to work with Oliver Nelson?

HJ: Yes.

MR: That was one of my favorite people and I'm sorry that he passed away.

HJ: It's terrible.

MR: What was distinctive about Oliver's writing, in your mind?

HJ: Well it's a composition and that sort of thing from Nadia Boulanger. And was able to use a lot of what he learned in his own music, I mean his music would have been different without that. And at the same time he was making records with Jimmy Forrest and King Curtis, you know, down home boogie stuff. But I loved his writing.

MR: I thought it was really interesting on his "Stolen Moments" you know first you have Freddie Hubbard, then you had Eric Dolphy and they're like all over the place sort of, and then he comes in just with his [scats].

HJ: Yeah. I use those solo notes as background notes in my arrangement of "Stolen Moments." Do you know that one at all?

MR: Yeah.

HJ: Does anything get past you? You're very well informed.

MR: Well I appreciate your saying that. Not much gets past you. I appreciate all the things

HJ: Still do. I'm still learning.

MR: Do you have favorite recordings of your own?

HJ: I like all of my recordings. There are only four of them, or is there five? Four.

MR: I'm happy to hear you say that because some people say, "Oh, I never listen to what I record. I could have done better."

HJ: Yeah. Well Miles Davis always said that but not for any reason like that.

MR: Yeah. Different phraseology.

HJ: He said that once it's recorded he doesn't want to hear it anymore because that's going back. He doesn't want to go back. He only wants to go forward. As a result, when we did, the last thing he did with the orchestra in Montreux with the Gil Evans arrangements and Quincy Jones conducting, when he was doing that, Gil Goldstein had sent him the parts in March or something like that, for this concert in the summer. He hadn't cracked those parts open and he wasn't ready with the chops or the concept when the concert actually went on. He got away with it. He only got lost once and he had Wallace Roney to pick up for him.

MR: And he was there.

HJ: Who?

MR: You. And I'm jealous. That's great. How's the music business been as far as the scope of your life.

HJ: If we're talking about business I'd say atrocious.

MR: Okay. I was going to talk about business, yeah.

HJ: Yes. Made for some but whoever is deciding who gets what I don't know.

MR: The shares aren't always divided up the way they should be? Is that a fair statement?

HJ: Yeah. By the way there's something I thought of asking about because I noticed wasn't Hamilton College —

MR: Yes.

HJ: That the Archive has a lot to do with Joe Williams.

MR: Exactly, yes.

HJ: I got a big criticism from Joe Williams for having done the Miller Lite commercial.

MR: Yeah?

HJ: He said I misrepresented jazz and —

MR: Did you arrange it?

HJ: No. I just appeared in it. He said it was making fun of our speech and he said I know better than to think we actually do that.

MR: Oh. Well I'll tell you that Joe Williams did a commercial himself for a beer.

HJ: I didn't know that.

HJ: What?

MR: He did. I have it on a video, his face is not on it, they're showing this — the whole thing is there's a keg of Carlsberg Light beer inside a big block of ice. And someone is chipping away at it. Meanwhile Joe Williams is singing, "Carlsberg Light, It's all right." It's like this little blues riff. So there you go. I'm glad to be able to tell you that.

HJ: I love it.

MR: Yeah he was a man of — he had strong opinions about some things and on occasion he got me too because I didn't deal with him a lot but every once in a while if I said something that he didn't like or agree with he would give me that look and he'd like open his eyes really wide and of course he kind of — like whoa — I felt like you in the Five Spot trying to be small. How are we doing for time?

HJ: That's all?

MR: Say it again?

HJ: That's all?

MR: Hour ten minutes. Time flies, right?

NO: He has stories that you could be here for several days.

MR: I know. I'm willing to keep talking for a while if you're up for it.

HJ: I don't mind as long as my droopy, drifting eyes don't bother you.

MR: Okay. What do you listen to now? Do you like to listen to music now?

HJ: Yeah I do. The newest stuff I hear is on WGBO. I haven't gone much deeper into things. I almost never do KCR. They have interesting stuff.

MR: You said KCR makes me think of Phil Schaap.

HJ: Yeah, is he there no longer?

MR: I don't know, I think he's still there, but there's a guy that nothing gets past him.

HJ: I had a chance to kind of get even with him because he kept pumping me about this idea of multiple instruments. And what you can get out of the instruments you play. And I insisted that there were no limitations to what you can get out of what instrument, it just hasn't been discovered yet. And so he had this thing, it seemed like he was ready in advance, about how well there are limitations and you say it isn't finished. But no one can say it until everything has been tried, he was kind of like, "What?" So I said well that hasn't been my experience. My experience is that if a saxophone player wants to play like a trombone and slide like that, if that's what it takes for him to express himself he'll do it. She'll do it. It's like it's just a matter of opportunity to do what you think you ought to do. I never said I'm going to innovate the tuba into modern jazz. I never thought like that. It's just a sound I wanted to make. And it goes for the baritone sax too 'cause nobody plays like me.

MR: You had your own sound for sure. And most of the people who innovate aren't aware that it's a conscious effort I think. That's what makes it so terrific.

HJ: Um hum.

MR: Yeah.

HJ: Even Roland Kirk, who you have to say put a little bit of thought into what he was going to do, I mean, you wouldn't imagine playing three saxophones was a good idea just one day and decide to go and do it. It evolved. And he was an evolving cat too. He used to play baritone like Harry Carney. And flute. He turned into a great flute player at a time when flute was still new and everybody was getting one. His sound was so far ahead of everybody.

MR: Well I'm going to try one last question on you, then we'll wrap up. You just used the word "evolve." Some people feel that jazz music helped to bring blacks and whites together before it happened in the rest of society. I wonder if you have a thought about that?

HJ: Oh. That's some territory to explore. I don't know how much together black and white players are even still. There are some who are resentful, some whites who are resentful and feel that black players get picked over them in some circumstances. And then there's the other end of that which is that you see certain things like big band things, just about everybody has a rehearsal band concept or other where they can go down and rehearse for three hours and just have a bunch of fun. These bands are mostly white and they don't want black players. They say so.

MR: Wow.

HJ: They say, "Yeah well the black guys don't use the same kind of tuning we do. Their precision is a little off you know, there. Can't be trusted to carry the load properly." And I actually try to work against that. What's his name, Ed Palermo? Whenever I see Ed Palermo rehearsing at the union I'll come in the door and I'll act like I'm counting to see the ratio of white to black. There was never any blacks. So when Ed speaks to me, when he sees I'm there he speaks to me, all I say is, "Get some brothers in here man."

MR: Well I wish he'd pay attention. Well that's a good way to end today.

HJ: Well just a second.

MR: Okay.

HJ: The great engineer Jim Anderson, who did a lot of wonderful recordings for us all, asked somebody when he was doing a big band, asked somebody why are there not any black players in the band. And the guy very openly told him what I just said, you know. Not reliable with the pitch and yada-yada-yada. So when Cecil Bridgewater came in to do that last big band record of Dee Dee Bridgewater, Jim Anderson came over and said, "Are

they're excellent players." Cecil went, "Well thank you." He went, "But they're all black." And told Cecil what people had been telling him. Cecil first looked around the room and went, "Oh, you're right." Because it's no big thing. You know it just turned out that way. There wasn't anything like, "Don't get any white guys." So where does any of that stand? It's impossible to know or at least hard to know.

MR: Okay. Well thanks for all you have contributed to American music and we didn't get to talk even about your tuba ensembles but those are innovative and important, and I really appreciate your time today.